MADE IN INDIA

We are doing well in a lot of areas, but is it really glory days forward for India Inc.?

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There has been a lot of talk surrounding the Indian Government's Make in India initiative. Apart from the obvious political significance, the program, launched in September 2014, was a bid to increase foreign investment in India and encourage industries (Indian and international) to set up shop in our country. And even if we put the specific undertakings of this one particular program aside, the changes in India's manufacturing, design and entrepreneurship scenario is not ignorable. In fact, it would actually be wrong to credit just this one programme for the everything that has changed. For instance, did you know that the growing number of food delivery startups in India has contributed to the increased factory output of the country? Similarly, India is increasingly becoming the preferred nation when it comes to cheap labour thanks to labour prices in China rising. We could also soon be the first country to have a privately-funded space mission to the moon thanks to TeamIndus. We'll try to cover all these aspects and more, starting, obviously, with the startups.

STARTUP INDIA

Let's face it, there seems to be a startup for everything in India today. In fact, there are even startups that make other startups (called incubators and accelerators)! In the current market scenario we have a lot of companies that started off as startups and are currently competing against many established rivals in their field. Take the now popular wallet service PayTM for instance. After last year's demonetisation of ₹1000 and ₹500 notes and the subsequent lack of cash, digital payment providers saw a huge growth in adoption and usage. For a significant period of time, PayTM registered more than 5 million transactions a day! Their growth hasn't stopped since. Just recently, they also launched their Payments Bank which provides basic banking services to existing customers.

Big names like Swiggy are getting into cloud kitchens

And payments is not the only startup area that is growing. Food tech startups, especially cloud kitchens as compared to restaurant aggregators, are showing a lot of promise with leading providers like Swiggy and Zomato getting into the cloud kitchen business this year. This particular way of innovating helps these startups move into a profitable model since they have control over the entire process, as compared to merely making a cut of the money as aggregators. And that's a big factor for any startups out there from the survivability perspective. According to a report by the Indian Brand Equity Foundation – a trust set up by the commerce ministry – India's food delivery market alone is worth $15 billion today! In fact, the growing tendency to order food from outside